

futures. Others mentioned 80 percent, 85 percent, and 90 percent. What's more, they tossed out these figures as if they were of no particular concern.

Nobody in the futures industry seemed to keep statistics on how many losers and winners there actually were. I contacted Mike Smith at the Futures Industry Association in Washington, who said he didn't know of any studies on the subject, and also called it "a privileged type of information." He mentioned a study from the University of Illinois that claimed 90 percent of the investors in commodities lost money, but it was done in the 1950s. "To determine such a thing today would not only be impractical, but an infringement on our fiduciary responsibilities to the industry," said Mr. Smith.

From him, I received some general market surveys commissioned by the futures industry. These were most interesting for what was omitted. In one, the researchers asked everything from "What periodicals do you read?" to "Do you enjoy talking to your broker?" but they never got around to "Have you made or lost money?" The closest they came to the apparently troublesome question was: "Are you satisfied with your performance?" and "Do you plan to make future investments in commodities?" Thirty percent of those interviewed said they had no plans to make any further investments, and from that I presumed they lost money. If Mr. Epstein's estimate was correct, then losing money was no deterrent to another 60 percent of the unfortunates who stayed in the market.

I held my futures and options for 48 hours as I learned of the odds against me. I called the trading desk at Lind-Waldock to review my progress and discovered that my \$2,000 had grown to \$2,265 in two days.

This \$265 increase wouldn't have impressed me otherwise, but given what I'd lately discovered, it seemed like a remarkable achievement. I was only too happy to sell out immediately—live hogs, deutsche-mark straddle, and corn. Though I'd planned to hold my positions much longer, I now knew there was an 80–95 percent chance I'd end up a loser, while my \$265 profit put me in very special company with the tiny clique of winners. In fact, in carrying this \$265 out across an entire year, I realized I'd made